

A TOOLKIT FOR BOTH EMPLOYEES AND MANAGERS

CREATED BY MERCEDES VAN NIEKERK

Career Conversations



Before the Conversation

EXPLORE YOUR CAREER, MAPPED

Before starting a career conversation, spend a little time exploring what might be possible.

Your Career, Mapped is an interactive career mobility tool designed to help you understand the capabilities you already have, where they could take you, and what you might want to build next.

You do not need to know where you want to go before you start.



WHERE AM I NOW?



WHERE COULD THOSE SKILLS TAKE ME?



WHAT SKILLS DO I ALREADY HAVE?



HOW COULD I GET THERE?



Contents



WHAT ARE CAREER CONVERSATIONS?

A SHARED CONVERSATION: EMPLOYEE & MANAGER

CONVERSATION WORKSHEETS

MAPPING YOUR POSSIBILITIES

BUILD YOUR DEVELOPMENT ROUTE

THREE MINI CAREER SCENARIOS

AGREE YOUR NEXT STEPS, TOGETHER

30 DAY ACTION PLAN TASK

CHECK-INS

FINAL REMINDERS

What Are Career Conversations?

Career conversations are open, ongoing discussions about development, aspirations and possibilities – not just conversations about promotion or the next job.

Career conversations do not have to begin with: *“What job do you want next?”*

And they do not need to end with a five-year plan.



The difference between career conversations and performance reviews

Performance reviews tend to be more **backwards looking and reflective**.

The focus is on questions such as:

- How have I done?
- What progress have I made?
- Have I reached my objectives?

On the other hand, **career conversations are future orientated**:

- Where am I going?
- What might I need to learn?
- What can I explore?

IMPORTANTLY, FORMAL CAREER CONVERSATIONS SHOULD BE SEPARATE FROM PERFORMANCE REVIEWS AND TAKE PLACE THROUGHOUT THE YEAR, RATHER THAN AS A ONE-OFF ANNUAL DISCUSSION.

A Shared Conversation

DIFFERENT ROLES



Career development works best when employees and managers both take an active role.

The employee owns their career.

The manager helps create the conditions to explore it.



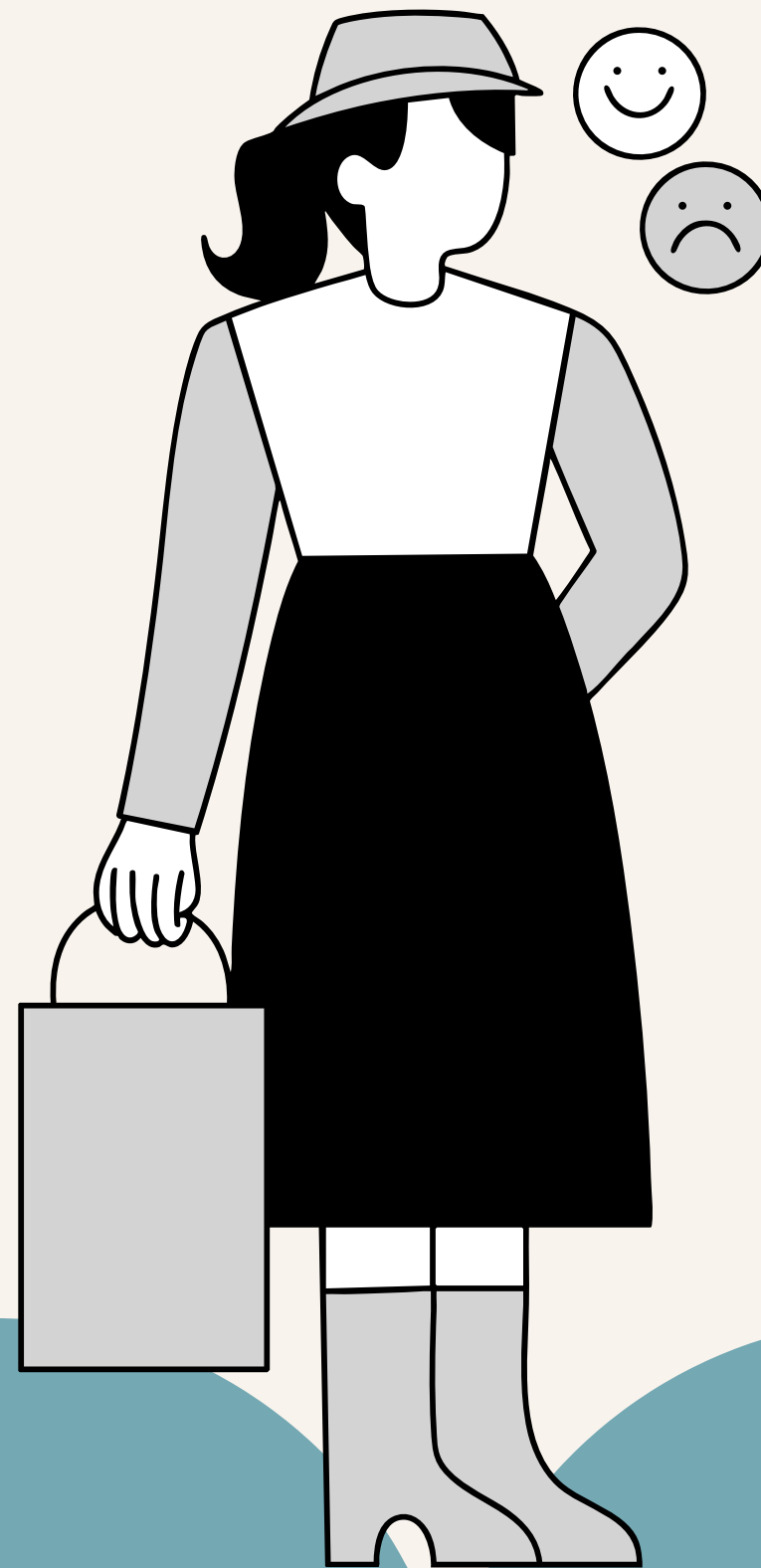
If you are the EMPLOYEE, you bring:

CURIOSITY

Be open to exploring skills, projects, functions and career possibilities — even if you are not yet sure where they might lead.

OWNERSHIP

Take an active role in your own development. Bring ideas to the conversation, follow up on opportunities and recognise that your manager can support your career, but cannot shape it for you.



REFLECTION

Think about what gives you energy, what you enjoy, where your strengths lie and what you would like more or less of in your work.

ACTION

Turn reflection and curiosity into something you can actually try. Agree a realistic next step and use the experience to learn more about yourself and what you might want next.

If you are the MANAGER, you bring :

PAGE 8

LISTENING

Create space for the employee to talk openly about what they enjoy, what they want more of and what they are curious about. Listen for patterns before jumping to solutions.

CONNECTING

Help make links between the employee's strengths, interests and possible opportunities. This might mean identifying another function, introducing them to someone, or spotting a useful development experience.



QUESTIONING

Use open questions to help the employee think more deeply about their strengths, motivations and possibilities, rather than telling them what they should do next.

SUPPORTING

Help turn the conversation into a realistic next step. Where possible, enable introductions, learning, projects or experiences — without over-promising what will be available.

Worksheets to get the conversation flowing...

PAGE 9

YOUR CAREER COMPASS

Before the conversation, build your Career Compass. Complete as much or as little as feels useful. Download and print or annotate your own version.

[CLICK HERE FOR CAREER COMPASS](#)

CAREER "WOULD YOU RATHER?"

Sometimes it is easier to understand what you want by comparing two possibilities. There are no right answers. Circle whichever feels more appealing right now.

[CLICK HERE FOR WOULD YOU RATHER?](#)

PICK A CONVERSATION CARD - MANAGERS

Questions for managers. You do not need to work through a script. Pick the questions that feel most useful.

[CLICK HERE FOR CONVERSATION CARDS](#)



Map Your Possibilities, Together

PAGE 10

Use Your Career, Mapped together. This tool can give the conversation somewhere concrete to go. Explore four things together.

1 WHERE ARE YOU NOW?

Look at the employee's current function.

- Which capabilities feel strongest?
- Which do they most enjoy using?
- Which do they want more opportunity to use?

3 WHAT ALREADY TRANSFERS?

Look at the bridge between functions.

- Which capabilities do you already have?
- Where have you demonstrated them?
- Which would give you confidence in a new context?

2 WHERE COULD THOSE SKILLS TAKE YOU?

Explore close, adjacent and stretch possibilities.

Do not ask: "Which of these jobs do you want?"

Try: "Which of these surprises or interests you?"

4 HOW COULD YOU GET THERE?

Treat the gap as a development prompt.

Ask: "What experience could help you build this?"

That is where the four development modes come in.

Build Your Route on Your Career, Mapped PAGE 11

Development does not have to happen in a particular order. You could punt, walk, cycle, or even ride the train to your next job destination. The mode describes the type and intensity of development.



PUNTING – EXPLORE

Punting is about curiosity without a big commitment. It is useful when:

- you are unsure whether something interests you;
- you want to understand another function;
- or you are beginning to think about a new capability.



CYCLING – TRY

Cycling is about applying capability in real work. It is useful when:

- you understand the basics;
- you want experience rather than more theory;
- or you are ready for greater responsibility.



WALKING – BUILD

Walking gives you structured exposure and learning. It is useful when:

- you have identified a development need;
- you need knowledge before taking on something new;
- or you want to strengthen capability within your current role.



TRAIN – EXPERIENCE

The Train represents more structured movement. It is useful when:

- direct experience is now the best development;
- the employee has significant transferable capability;
- or they are ready for a more formal move.

Three Mini Career Scenarios

Scenario 1

"I'M INTERESTED IN DEVELOPMENT, BUT I'VE NEVER WORKED DIRECTLY WITH DONORS."

Possible route:



Career conversation with a fundraiser



Relevant fundraising online workshops



Support a donor-facing project



Explore direct experience later if useful

Scenario 2

"I REALLY LIKE EVENTS. I DON'T WANT TO LEAVE, BUT I WANT TO PROGRESS."

Career development does not automatically mean moving function.

Possible route:



Lead a larger cross-functional event

Review what type of responsibility you want next

Scenario 3

"I LOVE THE ANALYTICAL SIDE OF MY ROLE, BUT HAVE NO IDEA IF BUSINESS INTELLIGENCE WOULD ACTUALLY SUIT ME?"

You do not need to decide yet.

Possible route:



Speak to somebody in BI



Develop data visualisation



Contribute to a dashboard or insight project

Agree the Next Steps Together

EMPLOYEE ASK:

“What will I do next?”

MANAGER ASK:

“What can I realistically help unlock?”

TOGETHER AGREE ON:

- The specifics

E.g. “Arrange a conversation with somebody in Donor Relations to understand what the team does and which skills would be useful to build”

- What support is needed
- When will you revisit it



30/60/90-Day Career Experiment

You do not need to transform your career this month. Choose one experiment, pick your timeline, and set your goals. You can use this tool as part of your career conversations check-ins to reflect on your progress once the time has passed.

Circle your mode:



Punting



Walking



Cycling



Train

In the next 30/60/90 days, I will:

I am hoping to learn:

Someone who could help:

The first step is:

Check In - What Did You Learn?

Career development is an experiment. The important part is to come back to the conversation. Sometimes the next step will be to go further. Sometimes it will be to change direction. Both are progress.

ASK YOURSELF:

- What did I learn?
- What did I enjoy?
- What did I not enjoy?
- What surprised me?
- Did I feel energised?
- Did I build the capability I expected?
- Am I more or less interested now?
- What would I like to try next?

MANAGERS ASK:

- What did you take from the experience?
- What did you notice about yourself?
- Has it changed your thinking?
- What would you like more of now?
- Should we go further in this direction?
- Is there another possibility we should explore?



Final Reminder

EMPLOYEES

You do not need to know your destination before you start exploring. Be curious. Notice what gives you energy. Understand the capabilities you already have. Try things. Learn from them. Take ownership of your next step.

MANAGERS

You do not need to know somebody else’s destination. Listen. Ask. Notice strengths. Challenge assumptions. Broaden possibilities. Make useful connections. Help create opportunities to learn.

CAREER DEVELOPMENT IS NOT ONE LADDER.

YOU CAN MOVE UPWARDS

SIDEWAYS

DIAGONALLY

DEEPER INTO SPECIALISM

INTO BROADER RESPONSIBILITY

OR TOWARDS SOMETHING YOU HAD NEVER PREVIOUSLY CONSIDERED



Useful Resources - Podcasts

PAGE 17

CAREER CONVERSATIONS:



Squiggly Shortcut: 5 Questions That Will Transform Your Career Conversations

January is always a good moment to pause, think about the big picture and zoom out when we're thinking about the...

 Squiggly Careers



How to have a career conversation

Did you know that 8/10 of us would be more engaged in our work if we were having regular career conversations but...

 Squiggly Careers

ON 'EXPERIMENTS':



How to use experiments to accelerate your career development

Experimentation is a great way to learn at work and accelerate opportunities for your career. In this podcast...

 Squiggly Careers

FOR EMPLOYEES:



How to take control of your career

Is it possible to take control of your career in a world of work that's full of change? Helen and Sarah think it is IF...

 Squiggly Careers



Squiggly Shortcut: Discover Hidden Career Opportunities in 5 Minutes a Day

In this Squiggly Career Shortcut, Helen shares five simple, everyday ideas that can have a big impact on your...

 Squiggly Careers

FOR MANAGERS:



How to help people to squiggle and stay

The majority of people look outside of their company first when they are considering making a career move. This...

 Squiggly Careers

Useful Resources - Videos



Useful Resources - Books and Courses

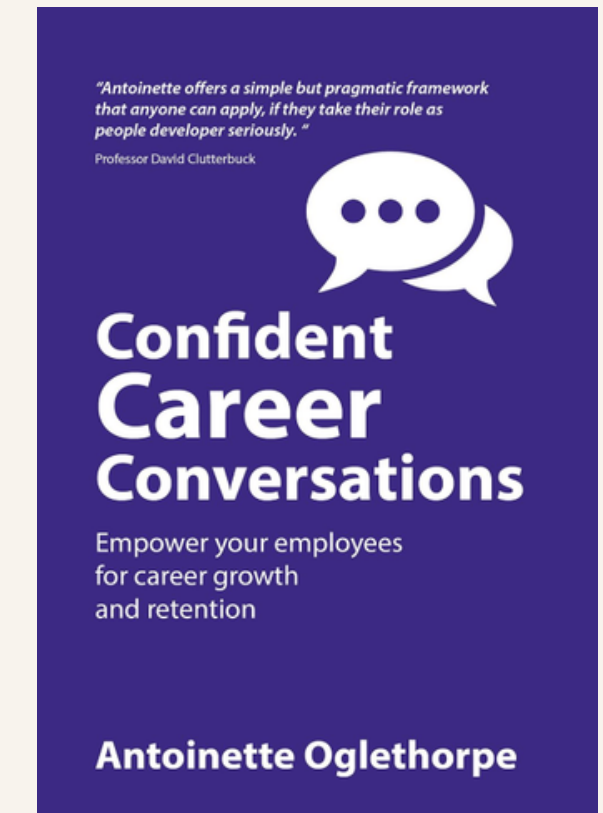
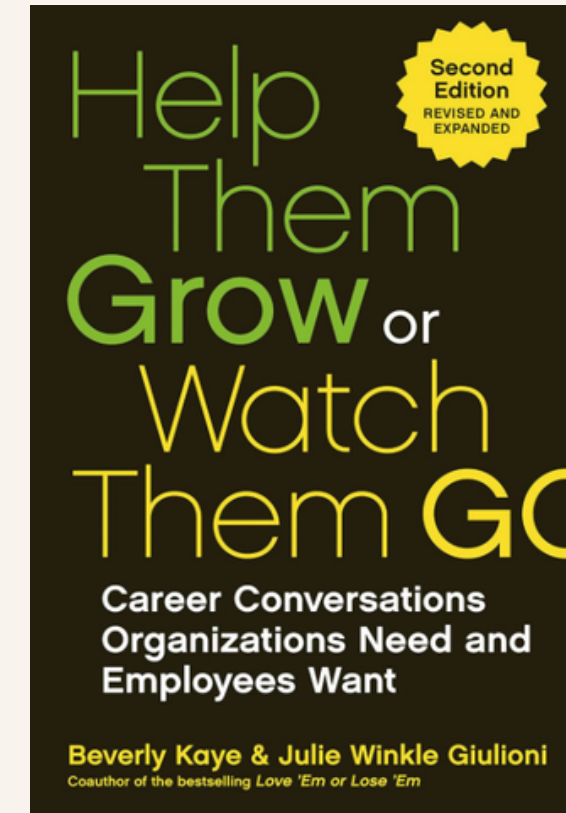
FOR MANAGERS:



Having Career Conversations with Your Team | LinkedIn Learning, formerly Lynda.com

Learn about a coaching framework that you can apply to help your team members quickly identify ideal outcomes...

linkedin



FOR EMPLOYEES:



Having an Honest Career Conversation with Your Boss | LinkedIn Learning, formerly Lynda.com

To get what you want, you need to ask. Dialog is what opens doors. If you're at the place in your career where y...

linkedin

